IN THE SADDLE
Vishnu Deo Sai after being named CM in Raipur, Dec. 10; (inset) deputy CMs Arun Sao (L) and Vijay Sharma



BHUPESH KESHARWANI

nouncement came on December 10, a week after the election results.

In naming Sai as CM, the BJP has given Chhattisgarh its first 'undisputed' tribal CM in the state's 23-year history. Born in Bagiya village in north Chhattisgarh's Jashpur district, Sai belongs to the Kanwar tribe, the second largest tribal group after the Gonds in the state. (While the late Ajit Jogi, who was sworn in as Chhattisgarh's first CM in November 2000, claimed to be a tribal, his Scheduled Tribe certificate was revoked in 2019.)

"The party felt that its victory was due to the tribal support, manifested in its exceptional performance in both north and south Chhattisgarh," says a state BJP functionary, not wishing to be named. The BJP won all 14 seats in the tribal-dominated Ambikapur division in north Chhattisgarh and eight out of the 12 seats in tribal-dominated south Chhattisgarh. In the end, it was a toss-up between a tribal face and one belonging to the Sahu community. But since the party fared better in tribal areas, winning 17 of the 29 seats reserved for STs, rather than in the OBC-dominated plains, where the Congress trumped it, the balance tilted in Sai's favour. Choosing a tribal CM, adds the party functionary, is also in line with

VISHNU DEO SAI, 59

PERSONAL BACKGROUND: Born in Bagiya village in tribal-dominated Jashpur district, from Kanwar tribe

EDUCATION: After studying at a Jesuit-run school, opted for B.Sc., but dropped out within a year

FAMILY: Married Kaushalya Devi in 1991, has two daughters and a son

POLITICAL TRAINING: Elected panch of his village in 1989, then sarpanch; entered MP state assembly on BJP ticket in 1990; four-time Lok Sabha MP from Raigarh (1999-2019)

POSTS HELD: Appointed Union minister of state in Modi's first term (2014-2019); also Chhattisgarh BJP chief in 2011 and 2020-2022

WORK STYLE: Low-profile, known for his affable nature and clean image